

ARC 5 · STORIES ABOUT JESUS, 41-50

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# The Beginning and the End

*Ten stories about Jesus, fully prepped.*



THE TEN STORIES

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A few days before your table meets, learn the story the way hosts have always learned stories: **Recite, Retell, Recall.**

**RECITE**

Read it out loud to yourself a few times during the week.

**RETELL**

Say it in your own words with the text nearby to check yourself.

**RECALL**

Tell it with the text closed. That is it.

**OR READ IT FIRST**

Cannot get it cold? Read it aloud, close the book, tell it anyway — and ask the table to catch what you drop.

Twenty minutes across a week. Nobody is asking you to memorize a script — the five Cs are all you need to hold in your head, and every story here comes with them already worked out.

The sample telling is training wheels, not a script. It is told, never read — reading aloud makes a classroom, telling makes a table.

# No Room

Read it first: Luke 2:1–20

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

Rome runs the world, and Caesar Augustus orders a census — everyone to their ancestral town to be counted and taxed. So a poor carpenter and his very pregnant fiancée travel to Bethlehem, because empire says move.

### CHARACTERS

Mary and Joseph, far from home. An overcrowded town with no guest space. Shepherds in the night fields — low-status workers on the graveyard shift. An angel army. A newborn.

### CONFLICT

No room. The King of the universe arrives, and there is no space for him anywhere respectable — so he's born where the animals are, and laid in a feeding trough.

### CLIMAX

The birth announcement — the most important news in history — goes not to Caesar, not to the temple, but to shepherds in a field at night: *the Savior — yes, the Messiah, the Lord — has been born today in Bethlehem. And you will recognize him by this sign: a baby wrapped snugly in strips of cloth, lying in a manger.* Then the sky fills with the armies of heaven, singing.

### CHANGE

The shepherds run to town, find everything exactly as announced, tell everyone what they'd heard — the first people ever to spread the news of Jesus — and go back to their flocks glorifying God. Mary keeps all these things in her heart. God has entered the world at the bottom of it, and the trajectory of the whole story is set in the first scene.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

Start with who's in charge, because the story does: Caesar Augustus, the most powerful man alive, signs a decree — a census, the whole Roman world, everyone back to their ancestral town to be registered and taxed. That's why a poor carpenter named Joseph is on the road from Nazareth to Bethlehem with Mary, who is due any day. They didn't choose the timing. Empire moved them like pieces on a board. Remember that; God is about to enter the world as one of the pushed-around.

Bethlehem is stuffed — everyone's ancestral cousins came for the same census — and for this couple there's no place in any guest room. So when the time comes, Mary gives birth where the animals are kept, wraps her firstborn son snugly in strips of cloth, and lays him in a manger. A feeding trough. Hold that picture without rushing past its strangeness: the maker of the universe, minutes old, sleeping where the livestock eat, because the world he made had no room for him. It's the first thing the story tells us about how this is all going to go — and where he'll be found from now on: not in the palace, not in the temple, but out back with the ones nobody made room for.

Meanwhile, in the fields outside town, shepherds are on the night watch. Be clear about who shepherds were: not greeting-card figures — low-wage, low-status workers, out with animals in the dark, near the bottom of everyone's list. Which is exactly whose sky rips open.

An angel of the Lord appears, and the glory of the Lord floods the field, and they are — Luke's honest about it — terrified. And the angel says: "Don't be afraid! I bring you good news that will bring great joy to all people. The Savior — yes, the Messiah, the Lord — has been born today in Bethlehem, the city of David!" And then the sign, and listen to how odd it is: "You will recognize him by this: you will find a baby wrapped snugly in strips of cloth, lying in a manger."

That's the sign. Not a crown. Not a comet over a palace. You'll know it's God because you'll find him *in the feeding trough*. The lowliness isn't the obstacle to the glory; it's the identification mark.

Then the night explodes — suddenly the angel is joined by the armies of heaven, a sky full of them, praising God: "Glory to God in highest heaven, and peace on earth to those with whom God is pleased!" The greatest birth announcement ever made — and its entire audience is a handful of shepherds. Caesar, who set the whole story in motion, never hears a thing.

The shepherds run — "let's go to Bethlehem and see this thing that has happened" — and find Mary and Joseph, and the baby, lying in the manger, everything exactly as they were told. And then they can't keep quiet: they tell everyone what the angel said about this child, and everyone who hears is astonished. The first people ever to

spread the news about Jesus are night-shift livestock workers. That's not an accident of casting. That's the announcement about the announcement.

And Mary — Luke keeps this detail like a pressed flower — treasured all these things in her heart and thought about them often.

The shepherds went back to their flocks, glorifying and praising God. Back to the same fields, the same job, the same night shifts — but having seen where God chooses to arrive. Which is the whole point of telling this story at a table in an ordinary house: he still starts small, low, and close to the ground. No room required. A manger will do. A living room will do fine.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about God — where he chooses to arrive, and who he tells first?
- 03 Where are you in this story — pushed around by forces you didn't choose, out on a night shift, or holding something you're treasuring quietly like Mary?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

#### AN ACT

Take good news to a shepherd this week — someone on the world's night shift: the overlooked worker, the person at the bottom of the org chart, the one nobody announces anything to first. Give them the honor of being told first, included first, thanked first — whatever "first" is in your reach.

# The Baptism

Read it first: Mark 1:9–11

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

John the Baptist is out at the Jordan River preaching repentance, and all kinds of people are coming to be baptized — confessing, turning, starting over. And one day, in the line of sinners, stands Jesus of Nazareth.

### CHARACTERS

John, the wild prophet. The crowds of the repenting. Jesus — thirty years old, having done, as far as anyone knows, nothing yet. And the voice from heaven.

### CONFLICT

Jesus has nothing to repent of — yet he gets into the same water, in the same line, as everyone else. His first public act is total identification with the people he came for.

### CLIMAX

As he comes up out of the water: the heavens split open, the Spirit descends on him like a dove, and a voice from heaven says: *You are my dearly loved Son, and you bring me great joy.*

### CHANGE

Note what Jesus has accomplished when those words are spoken: no miracles, no sermons, no followers, no cross. Nothing. The belovedness comes *before* the résumé — identity before achievement — and everything Jesus does for the next three years, he does *from* that voice, not *for* it. The water, and the words over it, set the pattern for every child of God since.

## A SAMPLE TELLING

Out at the Jordan River, John the Baptist is doing the thing that made him famous: preaching that people should turn their lives around and be baptized to show they'd turned. And it's working — crowds are streaming out from everywhere, wading into the river, confessing what they'd done, coming up wet and new. It's a line of people admitting things. A river full of fresh starts.

And one day, in that line, stands Jesus of Nazareth.

Let the strangeness of that register. This is the one person in the line with nothing to confess. And his very first public act — the first thing he ever does in front of anyone — is to get into the water *with everybody else*. Not above the line, blessing it. In it. Same river, same crowd, same posture as every sinner and second-chancer on that bank. Before he preaches a word, Jesus answers the question every burned and doubtful person carries — *is he with us or above us?* — with his feet. He's in the water. He starts his whole mission by standing where we stand.

So John baptizes him. And as Jesus comes up out of the water, Mark says three things happen, fast. The heavens *split open* — Mark's word is violent, torn, like fabric ripping; whatever separated heaven and earth just got torn through and it doesn't get sewn back. The Spirit descends on him like a dove, gentle as the tearing was fierce. And a voice comes from heaven:

"You are my dearly loved Son, and you bring me great joy."

Now here is the center of this story, and maybe of everything, so walk slowly. Ask: what has Jesus done at this point? What's on the résumé when the Father says that?

Nothing. No miracles yet. No sermons. No disciples, no healings, no cross, no resurrection. Thirty quiet years in Nazareth — sawdust and family dinners and ordinary days. And *before any of it*, the Father tears the sky open to say: you are my Son. I love you dearly. You are my joy.

The love comes before the accomplishments. The identity comes before the mission. Jesus doesn't spend the next three years working toward that voice — earning it, auditioning for it. He works *from* it. Every temptation he's about to face in the desert (that's next week's story) will attack exactly this — "if you are the Son of God..." — and he'll stand on this moment every time. When you know whose you are, the wilderness can't rename you.

And that's why this story belongs to everyone at this table, not just to him. Because the pattern set at that river is the pattern of the whole family he came to make: beloved *first*. Not "get it together and then God will delight in you." The voice speaks over the unaccomplished. Whatever you did or didn't get done this week — whatever résumé you brought to this table or failed to — the order of operations in God's house was fixed at the Jordan: loved, then sent. Never the other way around.



He got in the water with us. The sky tore open. And the first words through the tear were about love.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about God — the timing of "dearly loved," before anything was accomplished?
- 03 Where are you in this story — still working for the voice, or learning to work from it? What would change this week if you actually believed it was already said over you?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

AN ACT

Say the voice's words over someone who hasn't earned them yet — a child, a struggling friend, someone mid-failure: *I love you, and you're my joy — not for what you did, just because you're you.* Out loud or in writing. Most people have never once heard it without a "because" attached. And receive it once yourself this week: sit for five quiet minutes with the sentence addressed to you, and don't argue with it.

# The Wilderness

Read it first: Matthew 4:1-11

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

Straight from the baptism — from *you are my dearly loved Son* — the Spirit leads Jesus into the wilderness to be tested. Forty days of fasting. He is very hungry, very alone, and the tempter picks that moment.

### CHARACTERS

Jesus, at his physically weakest. The devil. And offstage but present in every answer: the Scriptures Jesus stands on.

### CONFLICT

Three offers, each aimed at the same hinge — *if you are the Son of God*: turn stones to bread (use the power for yourself), leap from the temple (force God to perform, dazzle the crowds), and finally, all the kingdoms of the world in exchange for one bow (take the throne without the cross).

### CLIMAX

Three refusals, each answered from Scripture — man does not live by bread alone; do not test the Lord your God; worship the Lord your God and serve only him. The third comes with a command: *Get out of here, Satan*.

### CHANGE

The devil leaves — Luke adds, ominously, *until the next opportunity* — and angels come and care for Jesus. Every shortcut to the mission without the cross has been laid on the table and refused: spectacle, self-service, and empire. Read the list again slowly; it's a map of every temptation power has ever faced — and everything Jesus's own movement would later be offered, and too often take.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

Remember where we left Jesus: dripping wet at the Jordan, the sky torn open, the voice still ringing — *you are my dearly loved Son*. And the very next thing that happens is this: the Spirit leads him into the wilderness. Not as punishment. To be tested. As if the belovedness had to be tried before it could be spent.

Forty days he fasts out there, alone in the rock and heat. And Matthew notes, with magnificent understatement, that afterward *he was very hungry*. And that — the weakest, hungriest, loneliest hour — is when the tempter comes. He always picks that hour. Worth knowing about your own wilderness.

Listen to how every temptation begins: "If you are the Son of God..." Hear what's being attacked. Not Jesus's morals — his *identity*. The voice at the river said *you are my Son*; the voice in the desert says *if*. Prove it. Perform it. Secure it yourself. Every temptation that follows is a shortcut offered to a hungry man: three ways to have the mission without the cost.

First: "If you are the Son of God, tell these stones to become bread." He's starving; he has the power; who would it hurt? And Jesus answers from Scripture: "People do not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God." The power is real — and it is not for serving himself. He'll multiply bread later, thousands of loaves of it — for *other* people. Never once for his own stomach.

Second, the devil takes him to the highest point of the temple — and this time brings Scripture of his own, quoting the psalm about angels catching you. "If you are the Son of God, jump! God will catch you — it's in the Bible." Imagine it: a public miracle over the temple courts, angels in view of everyone, instant credibility, no slow years of tables and roads. Jesus: "The Scriptures also say, 'You must not test the Lord your God.'" He will not force his Father's hand, and he will not build faith on spectacle. Dazzled crowds are not disciples — he'd rather be believed slowly at dinner tables than gasped at once from the sky.

Third, the mask comes off. A very high mountain, all the kingdoms of the world and their glory spread out below. "I will give you all of this," the devil says, "if you will kneel down and worship me." There it is — the real offer, the one the first two were softening him up for: the *throne without the cross*. Rule everything; skip Golgotha; one small bow. And notice the devil isn't offering anything Jesus wasn't going to receive anyway — he's offering the shortcut. The kingdom by seizure instead of by sacrifice. Power over people instead of love poured out for them.

"Get out of here, Satan," Jesus says. "For the Scriptures say, 'You must worship the Lord your God and serve only him.'"

And the devil leaves — Luke adds a chilling little clause: *until the next opportunity* — and angels come and take care of him.

Now stand back and read the three refusals as one list, because together they're a map: power used for self — refused. Spectacle to win crowds — refused. Empire, control, the top of every kingdom — refused. Jesus declined, in his first forty days, every shortcut that religion built in his name would later be offered — the self-serving comfort, the crowd-dazzling stage, the throne room of political power — and too often take. He chose bread broken for others, faith grown slowly at tables, and a kingdom that arrives by dying for people rather than ruling them. The wilderness is where the shape of everything got decided. And it was decided by a hungry man standing on one sentence: *you are my dearly loved Son* — no "if" about it.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — what he refused, and what each refusal protected?
- 03 Where are you in this story — which of the three shortcuts (comfort for self, applause, control) knocks loudest at your door? And where does the "if" attack your own identity?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

#### AN ACT

Refuse one shortcut this week, out loud to yourself when it shows up: the corner cut for your own comfort, the thing done for the audience instead of the good, the moment you could take control instead of serving. Name which of the three it was. Knowing their faces is half the wilderness.

# The Hometown Announcement

Read it first: Luke 4:14–30

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

Fresh from the wilderness, full of the Spirit's power, Jesus has been teaching around Galilee to growing acclaim. Then he comes home — to Nazareth, to the synagogue he grew up in, on the Sabbath, and stands up to read.

### CHARACTERS

Jesus. The hometown congregation — people who watched him grow up, *Joseph's son*. The scroll of Isaiah. And, invoked from the old stories: a widow in Sidon and a Syrian general.

### CONFLICT

He reads Isaiah's mission text — good news to the poor, freedom for captives, sight for the blind, the oppressed set free — rolls up the scroll, and says: *this Scripture has come true today before your very eyes*. The room is impressed... until he refuses to perform hometown miracles and reminds them that God's mercy has always jumped the fence — Elijah sent to a foreign widow, Elisha healing a foreign general.

### CLIMAX

The synagogue crowd — his neighbors, mid-service — erupts into fury, drags him out of town to the edge of the hill, intending to throw him off the cliff.

### CHANGE

He passed right through the crowd and went on his way. The mission statement stands, read aloud and claimed: the poor, the captive, the blind, the crushed. And the story has told us, in chapter one of his ministry, exactly what announcing that mission costs — and that grace refusing to stay inside the fence is what people find most unforgivable about it.

## A SAMPLE TELLING

Jesus came home. He'd been teaching all over Galilee, fresh from the wilderness, and word had spread — the hometown boy was becoming somebody. And on the Sabbath he went, as usual, to the synagogue in Nazareth. The one he grew up in. These people watched him learn to walk. Half of them had furniture he'd made.

He stands up to read, and they hand him the scroll of Isaiah. And he unrolls it to a specific place — he chose this — and reads:

"The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, for he has anointed me to bring Good News to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim that captives will be released, that the blind will see, that the oppressed will be set free, and that the time of the Lord's favor has come."

Then he rolls the scroll back up, hands it to the attendant, and sits down — which was the teaching posture; sitting down meant now I'll tell you what it means. Every eye in the room is on him. And he says one sentence:

"The Scripture you've just heard has been fulfilled this very day."

Sit in that moment. He just read the job description of the Messiah — the ancient hope, the thing every synagogue had been waiting on for centuries — and said: *that's me*. It starts today. And hear the job description again, because it's the mission statement of everything the other forty-nine stories in this canon show him doing: good news to *the poor*. Release to *captives*. Sight to *the blind*. Freedom for *the crushed*. When people ask what Jesus came to do, this is the answer he himself chose, read aloud, in his home church.

At first, the room is *charmed*. Everyone speaks well of him — such gracious words! — and then the hometown math starts: "Wait. Isn't this Joseph's son?" The carpenter's kid. And underneath the murmur, an expectation Jesus names out loud before they can: you're going to say, *do here in your hometown the miracles we heard you did in Capernaum*. Us first. Family discount. The hometown gets the front of the line.

And Jesus says no — and then he does the thing that turns the room. He reminds them of two stories from their own Scriptures. There were many widows in Israel during the great famine of Elijah's day — and Elijah was sent to *none* of them, but to a foreign widow in Sidon. There were many lepers in Israel in Elisha's time — and the only one healed was *Naaman, a Syrian*. An enemy general.

In other words: God's mercy has never stayed inside the fence you built for it. It has a long history of jumping to the outsider, the foreigner, the wrong person — and it's about to do it again.

And the congregation — his neighbors, in the middle of a worship service — goes from admiring to *murderous* in about a minute. They mob him, drag him out of town to the edge of the hill Nazareth is built on, intending to throw him off the cliff. His first sermon at home nearly ends in his death. It won't be the last time telling the truth about how wide God's mercy runs gets him killed — next time, it will be.

But not today. Luke gives it one strange, quiet line: *he passed right through the crowd and went on his way.*

Two things to carry out of Nazareth. First, the mission statement — poor, captive, blind, oppressed — is not a phase he grew out of; it's the banner over everything, and any version of following him that drifts far from that list has drifted from him. Second, the cost: the fury didn't come when he claimed to be the Messiah. It came when he said the mercy wasn't *theirs* to ration. People can forgive a hometown boy for greatness. What they couldn't forgive was grace jumping the fence. It still tests every room it's announced in — including, sometimes, church ones.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — the mission he chose to read, and where he says God's mercy has always gone?
- 03 Where are you in this story — and honestly: where's your fence? Who's the "Sidon widow" your instincts say should be behind us in line?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

#### AN ACT

Take the mission statement literally once this week: one act aimed at one item on his list — the poor, the captive (lonely, imprisoned, trapped), the blind (someone who can't see a way forward), the oppressed. Pick the item that's nearest your actual life, and let the mercy jump one fence to get there.

# The Tables Turned

Read it first: Mark 11:15–18

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

The final week. Jesus has entered Jerusalem to shouts of Hosanna, and now he walks into the temple — into its outermost court, the Court of the Gentiles, the one space where the nations, the outsiders, were permitted to come near and pray. It has been converted into a currency exchange and livestock market.

### CHARACTERS

The money changers and dove sellers, running a required and profitable trade. The pilgrims being priced. The blind and lame, who come to him there. The chief priests, listening. Jesus.

### CONFLICT

The commerce wasn't optional corruption — it was the system: temple tax paid only in approved coinage (exchange rates apply), sacrifices requiring approved animals (markup applies). Religion had built a toll booth between people and God, and built it in the only courtyard the outsiders had.

### CLIMAX

Jesus drives out the buyers and sellers, overturns the money changers' tables and the dove sellers' benches, stops the through-traffic — and teaches, quoting their own prophets: *My Temple will be called a house of prayer for all nations — but you have turned it into a den of thieves.*

### CHANGE

Matthew adds what filled the cleared space: the blind and the lame came to him in the temple, and he healed them, and children were shouting praise. And Mark adds the cost: the chief priests and teachers of the law heard, and began planning how to kill him — but feared him, because the people were amazed. The one act of physical protest in Jesus's life was aimed at religious commerce blocking outsiders from prayer, and it put the countdown on his death.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

It's the final week of Jesus's life — he knows it; almost no one else does — and he walks into the temple in Jerusalem. Specifically into its vast outer courtyard, the



Court of the Gentiles. Understand what that space was *for*: it was the one place in the whole temple complex where the outsider could come — the foreigner, the seeker, the not-yet-one-of-us — to be near God and pray. The nations' courtyard. The temple's open door.

And it had been turned into a marketplace.

Be fair about how it happened, because it happened reasonably — corruption usually does. Pilgrims came from everywhere, and the temple tax had to be paid in one approved coinage; so, money changers, with their tables and their exchange rates. Sacrifices required unblemished animals, impractical to carry from Cyrene or Rome; so, sellers of doves and livestock, at temple-court prices. Every booth was defensible. Every fee had a rationale. And the sum of all the reasonable pieces was this: the courtyard built for the outsider's prayer was now wall-to-wall commerce, and between an ordinary person and God stood a series of transactions — with the poor, who could only afford the doves, paying the steepest markups of all. Religion had built a toll booth in its own open door.

Jesus walks into that — and everything gentle in him goes quiet.

He begins driving out the buyers and the sellers. He overturns the money changers' tables — coins ringing across the stones — and flips the benches of the dove sellers. Mark adds a detail that shows how total it was: he stopped everyone from even carrying merchandise through the courts. The bazaar in God's house, shut down by one man's fury.

This is the only act of physical force in Jesus's entire life — mark that. Not against Rome. Not against the sinners, the prostitutes, the tax collectors; they got dinner invitations. The one time Jesus's anger became physical, it was aimed at *religious commerce* — at his own religion's machinery, profitably parked between people and God.

And then he teaches, right there in the wreckage, quoting their own prophets so no one can call it a new idea: "The Scriptures declare, 'My Temple will be called a house of prayer for all nations' — but you have turned it into a den of thieves." House of prayer *for all nations*. That's Isaiah — the door was always supposed to be open that

wide. Den of thieves — that's Jeremiah, a warning issued to the first temple before it fell. He's not vandalizing the temple. He's grieving what it was built to be.

And look what happens in the cleared space — Matthew tells us: the blind and the lame came to him there, in the temple, and he healed them. And children were running around the courts shouting praise. Turn that picture over in your hands: the tables go out, and *the blind, the lame, and the kids come in*. That's what the courtyard was for. That's what it looks like when the toll booth is gone.

Mark gives us the price tag in the very next verse: the chief priests and teachers of religious law heard what he'd done, and began planning how to kill him — held back only by their fear of the crowds, who were amazed at his teaching. The countdown to the cross starts here, in the courtyard. The religious machine could tolerate his healings, even his claims. What it could not survive was him flipping over its revenue in the name of an open door.

So here's the question this story hands to every generation that gathers in his name, including this table: what's parked in the courtyard now? Whatever stands between an outsider and prayer — a cost, a hoop, a culture, a toll of any kind — this story tells us exactly how Jesus feels about it. The gathering is free. It has to be. He flipped tables over this.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — the one thing that moved him to physical anger, and what filled the space he cleared?
- 03 Where are you in this story — being priced at the toll booth, or comfortable enough inside that you'd stopped noticing it was there? What "reasonable" thing might be blocking someone's way in?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

#### AN ACT

Clear one square foot of courtyard this week: identify one barrier — cost, awkwardness, jargon, an unspoken dress code, a "that's just how we do it" — that makes it harder for an outsider to get near God or near this table, and remove it or flag it to someone who can. And keep this table's own door checked: the gathering stays free, forever. That's not policy. That's this story.

# Gethsemane

Read it first: Mark 14:32–42

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

The last supper is over; the songs are sung. Jesus takes the disciples across to an olive grove called Gethsemane — a place he often went — knowing Judas knows it too, and is coming.

### CHARACTERS

Jesus, in an anguish the gospels describe with their strongest words. Peter, James, and John, asked to stay near and keep watch. The other disciples. And, arriving at the end: the betrayer.

### CONFLICT

Jesus tells his three closest friends the plain truth — *my soul is crushed with grief to the point of death; stay here and keep watch with me* — and goes a little farther, falls to the ground, and prays that if it were possible, the awful hour might pass him by: *Abba, Father, everything is possible for you. Please take this cup of suffering away from me.*

### CLIMAX

The prayer's second sentence, the hinge of history: *Yet I want your will to be done, not mine.* Three times he prays it; three times he returns to find his friends asleep — *couldn't you watch with me even one hour?* The spirit is willing, the body is weak, and he ends up doing the hardest praying of his life alone.

### CHANGE

He rises from the third prayer with the surrender complete — *up, let's be going; look, my betrayer is here* — and walks toward the torches. The struggle was real; the anguish was real; the asking-for-another-way was real. And the yes was real too. Everything after this — the arrest, the cross, the tomb, the morning — flows out of a prayer prayed facedown in an olive grove by a man who did not want to, and went anyway, held by his Father's will.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

The supper is finished. They sing the closing hymn — Passover ended with psalms; picture Jesus singing, knowing what the night holds — and he leads them across the valley to an olive grove called Gethsemane. He went there often; it was his praying

place. Which is exactly why he goes tonight: Judas knows the spot too. Jesus isn't hiding. He's keeping the appointment.

He leaves most of the disciples near the entrance and takes three — Peter, James, John — deeper in. And then the gospels use language about Jesus they use nowhere else: he became *deeply troubled and distressed*. And he tells his friends the plain, staggering truth: "My soul is crushed with grief to the point of death. Stay here and keep watch with me."

Stop and let that be as human as it is. This is Jesus — who slept through the storm, who stared down mobs and demons and never once flinched — telling three fishermen that his soul is being crushed, and asking them, please, to *stay close*. The Son of God, on the worst night in history, wanted his friends within earshot. Needing people near you in the dark isn't a failure of faith. It's the Lord's own request.

Then he goes a little farther — close enough that they heard the prayers they later reported — and falls to the ground. Not kneeling composed. Down, on the earth. And he prays:

"Abba, Father" — Abba, the intimate word, the child's word — "everything is possible for you. Please take this cup of suffering away from me."

Hear it without softening it: Jesus asked not to go to the cross. He looked into the cup — the betrayal, the abandonment, the nails, and whatever depths in it only he could see — and asked his Father, who could do anything, for another way. If you have ever begged God to take something away, you have prayed in Jesus's own footprints, in his own words. The request is not the sin. He made the request.

And then the second sentence, on which everything turns: "Yet I want your will to be done, not mine."

Both sentences, together — that's the whole prayer, and you can't cut either one. Honest anguish, and surrendered trust, in one breath, facedown in the dirt. Not *I'm fine with this* — he wasn't. Not *I refuse* — he didn't. But: *I don't want to* — and *I'm yours*. That's what surrender actually sounds like from the inside. Anybody who tells you it sounds calmer than that hasn't been to the garden.

He comes back to his three friends — and they're asleep. Grief-exhausted, Luke says kindly; it had been a night. "Simon, are you asleep? Couldn't you watch with me even one hour?" And then a sentence tender enough to keep forever, spoken by a man who needed them and forgave them in the same moment: "The spirit is willing, but the body is weak." He goes and prays the same prayer again. Returns — asleep again; they didn't know what to say. A third time. Three prayers, three sleeping friends. The most important praying ever done was done, in the end, alone, beside people who loved him and couldn't stay awake.

And then he stands up — and everything about him has changed. The anguish was poured out; what's left is resolve. "Up, let's be going. Look, my betrayer is here!" And torches come through the trees.

Here's what the garden gives everyone who will ever face a cup they didn't choose. Jesus didn't skip the struggle to get to the surrender — the struggle *was* the road to the surrender. He asked for removal and received strength instead, and the Father's no to the request was not a no to the Son. He was as beloved facedown in Gethsemane as he was coming up out of the Jordan. And when the yes finally came, it came from him freely — which means everything the cross gives us was *given*, by a man who saw the whole price in a dark garden, said out loud that he didn't want to pay it, and paid it anyway, for love. The salvation of the world came through a prayer that began with *please, no*.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — the honesty of the asking, and the shape of the yes?
- 03 Where are you in this story — is there a cup you've been praying past instead of praying *about*? And who are your three — the people you'd want within earshot on your worst night?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

**AN ACT**

Two acts, and they're the same act pointed two directions. Pray your Gethsemane prayer this week — both sentences: the honest *please take this away*, and, only if and when you can mean it, *yet your will, not mine*. (If you can only pray the first sentence right now, pray it; he'll keep company with you there.) And be the one who stays awake: someone near you is in a garden this week — ask them straight, "what's your hardest thing right now?", and then don't fall asleep on the answer. Check on them twice before your table meets again.

# The Cross and the Thief

Read it first: Luke 23:32–43

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

Golgotha. Jesus is crucified between two criminals — Rome's slowest, most public death, reserved for rebels and the worthless. The crowd watches; the leaders scoff; the soldiers gamble for his clothes.

### CHARACTERS

Jesus, on the center cross. Two criminals, one on each side. The mocking leaders and soldiers. And the sign over his head: *This is the King of the Jews*.

### CONFLICT

Three voices tempt him with the same taunt — *save yourself*: the leaders (if you're God's Messiah), the soldiers (if you're the king), and one of the criminals (aren't you the Messiah? Save yourself — and us while you're at it). The last temptation is the wilderness temptation again: come down, skip the cost, prove it.

### CLIMAX

The other criminal turns — first to rebuke his fellow (*we deserve this; this man has done nothing wrong*), and then to Jesus, with the barest prayer ever prayed: *Jesus, remember me when you come into your Kingdom*. And Jesus, mid-crucifixion, answers: *I assure you, today you will be with me in paradise*.

### CHANGE

A dying criminal — no baptism, no good works, no time left to change anything, nothing to offer but a name and a request — is promised paradise, personally, that day. Meanwhile Jesus's first words from the cross hang over the whole scene: *Father, forgive them, for they don't know what they are doing*. The final belief test was never administered. The mercy ran all the way to the last hour of the worst résumé on the hill.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

They crucified him at the place called The Skull, and two criminals with him — one on his right, one on his left. Rome designed crucifixion to be slow and public on purpose: a billboard of what happens to people who cross the empire. And over Jesus's head they nailed the charge, meant as mockery: *This is the King of the Jews*.

His first words from the cross — keep them in your ear for the whole story, because they're the weather over everything that follows: "Father, forgive them, for they don't know what they are doing." Spoken about the men driving the nails. While they drove them. Then the soldiers gambled for his clothes at the foot of the cross, and the mocking began.

Listen to the mockery, because it's all one taunt in three voices. The leaders scoff: "He saved others — let him save *himself* if he is really God's Messiah." The soldiers join in: "If you are the King of the Jews, save yourself!" Even one of the crucified criminals, dying beside him, throws it: "So you're the Messiah, are you? Prove it by saving yourself — and us, too, while you're at it!"

*Save yourself.* Do you hear it? It's the wilderness again — the same voice from the desert, back for what Luke called its next opportunity: *if you are the Son of God, take the shortcut, come down, skip the cost, dazzle them.* And the bitter irony the mockers can't see is that they're exactly right about the power and exactly wrong about the choice: he *could* come down. That's what makes staying up there the whole gospel. He's not trapped on the cross. He's *faithful* on it. The reason he won't save himself is that he's busy saving them.

But this story belongs to the other criminal. Something is happening in him as he hangs there dying — watching Jesus, hearing "Father, forgive them," reading that sign. And he speaks up, first to his mocking fellow: "Don't you fear God even when you have been sentenced to die? We deserve to die for our crimes — but this man hasn't done anything wrong." Honest confession, from a cross: *we deserve this; he doesn't.*

And then he turns his head to Jesus and prays the barest prayer ever prayed. No theology. No formula. Not even "forgive me." Just:

"Jesus, remember me when you come into your Kingdom."

Take the full measure of what this man does *not* have. No baptism. No good works — and no time left to do any; his hands are nailed down; he will never make restitution, never turn a new leaf, never attend anything. No credentials, no clean record, no tomorrow. He has a name — Jesus — and a request — *remember me* — and, somehow,



blazing through the pain, the wild faith to look at a fellow dying man and see a King with a Kingdom coming. That's the entire résumé.

And Jesus — laboring for every breath — turns to him and gives him more than he asked. He asked to be *remembered*, someday, whenever the Kingdom came. Jesus answers: "I assure you, today you will be with me in paradise."

Today. Not after probation. Not pending review. And not merely remembered — with *me*. Personal company, promised by name, from one cross to another. The last thing this man ever heard was the Son of God promising to keep him.

Here is why this story sits near the end of the canon, and why every table that ever worried about who qualifies should keep it close: the final belief test was never administered. At the last hour, with the worst record on the hill and nothing left to offer, a man asked Jesus to remember him — and the door opened all the way. Whatever else is true about how people come to God — and your church will teach you the riches of it — this is true, from Jesus's own lips, with his own dying breath: it is never too late, no one is too far gone, and the request can be seven words long. The thief made it in on nothing but Jesus. Which, it turns out, was always the only thing anyone made it in on.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — the "save yourself" he refused, and the "remember me" he answered?
- 03 Where are you in this story — still assuming you need a better résumé before you can ask? Or is there someone you've quietly decided is too far gone for a last-hour mercy?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

#### AN ACT

Retire one "too late" this week. If it's about you — the thing you've assumed disqualifies you — pray the thief's seven words and let today mean today. If it's about someone else — the person you wrote off, the relationship past its statute of limitations — make the reach you'd decided was pointless. Mercy at the eleventh hour is this story's whole specialty.

# The Garden and the Name

Read it first: John 20:1–18

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

Sunday, before dawn, the third day. Mary Magdalene — who stood at the cross when most had fled, who watched where the body was laid — comes to the tomb while it's still dark, and finds the stone rolled away.

### CHARACTERS

Mary Magdalene. Peter and John, who run to the tomb on her report, see the empty graveclothes, and go home. Two angels. And a man Mary takes for the gardener.

### CONFLICT

Mary stays when the men leave, weeping outside the tomb — grief on top of grief: he's dead, and now even the body is gone. *They have taken away my Lord, and I don't know where they have put him.* She says it to the angels; she says it to the gardener; she is looking straight at the risen Jesus and cannot see him through the tears.

### CLIMAX

One word. Not an argument, not a proof, not a flourish of glory. Her name: "Mary." And she turns and knows him instantly — "Rabboni!" — my Teacher.

### CHANGE

He gives her the first commission of the resurrection age: *go find my brothers and tell them.* And Mary Magdalene — a woman, whose testimony that world's courts wouldn't even count — becomes the first witness of the central event in history, running with the sentence the church has never stopped saying: *I have seen the Lord!* The resurrection announced itself not with an earthquake or an army, but by saying one grieving woman's name.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

It's Sunday, the third day, and still dark — John tells us that on purpose — when Mary Magdalene comes to the tomb. Know who she is before you watch what happens to her: Mary had been at the cross when nearly everyone else ran. She'd watched where they laid him. Her devotion had outlasted her hope; the hope died Friday, and she came anyway, in the dark, because love keeps appointments grief can't explain.

And the stone is rolled away.

She doesn't conclude *resurrection* — nobody does; that category doesn't exist yet. She concludes the only thing a reasonable, devastated person could: grave robbery. She runs for Peter and John — "They've taken the Lord's body out of the tomb, and I don't know where they have put him!" — and the two men race each other to the tomb (John, writing decades later, still makes sure you know he ran faster). They find the graveclothes lying there empty, the head cloth folded separately — details like an unmade bed, not a robbery — and John says he saw and believed *something*, though they didn't yet understand. And then, having seen the strangest sight of their lives, the two of them... go home.

Mary stays.

She stands outside the tomb weeping — and this is grief compounded: he's dead, *and now she can't even tend the body*. The last thing left to do for him, taken too. She stoops to look into the tomb and there are two angels — two angels! — and even they can't reroute her sorrow. "Why are you crying?" "Because they have taken away my Lord, and I don't know where they have put him." Then she turns around, and a man is standing there, and she supposes him to be the gardener.

Look at that moment before it resolves, because half your table lives in it. The risen Jesus — the answer to every tear she's crying — is standing directly in front of her, and she cannot recognize him. Grief does that; it can stand you face to face with hope and let you see only a gardener. He asks her the same question: "Why are you crying? Who are you looking for?" And she — still all devotion, this magnificent woman — makes the gardener an offer: "Sir, if you have taken him away, tell me where you've put him, and I will go and get him." She'll carry the body herself. She has no plan for how. Love like hers doesn't do logistics first.

And then Jesus says one word.

"Mary."

Just her name. Not "behold, I am risen" — no thunder, no proof presented, no glory unveiled. Her *name*, in the voice that had said it before — the voice that had once called her out of everything that held her. And she turns and everything turns with

her: "Rabboni!" — my Teacher — and you can hear that she's already holding onto him, because his next words are that she can't cling to him; there's somewhere he's going and something she must do.

And here's what he gives her, and it's the first assignment of the new world: "Go find my brothers and tell them." My *brothers* — the ones who fled, hiding behind locked doors, promoted to family in the first sentence of the resurrection age. And Mary Magdalene goes and becomes the first human being ever to say the sentence: "I have seen the Lord!"

Sit with the choice God made there. The first witness to the central event in all of history is a woman — in a world whose courts wouldn't even accept a woman's testimony. If you were inventing this story to convince that world, you would never write it this way; it's in there because it's what happened, and because it's *how* God *does things*, from the shepherds at the manger to the garden at dawn: the announcement goes first to the one the world would count last. And the resurrection introduced itself to the human race not with an earthquake — the earthquake was for the guards — but with a grieving woman's name, spoken gently, in a garden, before the sun was fully up.

He still tends to start that way. One name at a time.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — how he chose to be recognized, and who he chose to tell first?
- 03 Where are you in this story — staring at hope and seeing a gardener? And what would it mean to hear your own name in that voice — that he knows it, and says it, first?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

#### AN ACT

Say someone's name this week the way it was said in the garden — to someone grieving, invisible, or written off: greet them by name, speak to them by name, let them feel known instead of managed. And take Mary's job once: tell one person, in your own plain words, one thing you've seen God do. "I have seen" beats "I have heard" every time — it's the resurrection's own genre.

# Thomas

Read it first: John 20:24–29

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## THE FIVE CS

### CONTEXT

Easter evening: Jesus has appeared to the gathered disciples behind locked doors, shown them his hands and side, breathed peace on them. One of the Twelve missed it. Thomas wasn't there.

### CHARACTERS

Thomas — called the Twin; the one who once said *let's go die with him*; loyal, blunt, and now the only one who didn't see. The other disciples, glowing with news. And, a week later, Jesus.

### CONFLICT

The others keep telling him — *we have seen the Lord!* — and Thomas draws his line, concrete and absolute: *I won't believe it unless I see the nail wounds in his hands, put my fingers into them, and place my hand into the wound in his side.* And then he has to live inside that refusal, among the rejoicing, for eight days.

### CLIMAX

A week later, doors locked again, Thomas present this time — Jesus comes, stands among them, and goes straight to him, taking up Thomas's exact words: *Put your finger here, and look at my hands. Put your hand into the wound in my side. Don't be faithless any longer. Believe!* The evidence he demanded, offered without a flicker of shaming.

### CHANGE

Thomas — with no record that he ever actually touched — answers with the highest confession in the gospels: *My Lord and my God!* And Jesus adds the blessing that reaches out of the page to every table since: *You believe because you have seen me. Blessed are those who believe without seeing me.* The community kept Thomas for the week he couldn't believe; Jesus came back for him; and the loudest doubter became the clearest confessor. The canon ends its witness here on purpose.

### A SAMPLE TELLING

Easter evening, the disciples are behind locked doors — hiding, honestly — and Jesus comes and stands among them. Shows them his hands and his side. Breathes peace over them. The best night of their lives.

Thomas wasn't there.

We don't know why. Maybe grief does different things to different people, and his kind wanted to be alone. But he missed it — the one appearance, the whole vindication — and came back to a room full of transformed friends all saying the same impossible sentence: "We have seen the Lord!"

Before you hear his answer, remember who Thomas is, because the church nicknamed him so hard we forgot. This is the man who, when Jesus insisted on walking back into Judea where they'd just tried to stone him, said to the others: "Let's go, too — and die with him." Thomas is not the group's flaky skeptic. He's its blunt realist — loyal enough to volunteer for dying, and constitutionally unable to say he believes a thing he doesn't. So when the ten tell him a dead man is alive, Thomas answers like Thomas:

"I won't believe it unless I see the nail wounds in his hands, put my fingers into them, and place my hand into the wound in his side."

That's not a question; it's a specification. Concrete, physical, non-negotiable — the exact evidence or nothing. He's watched a crucifixion do what crucifixions do. He will not be talked into hope by secondhand joy, because he cannot survive losing him twice.

Now notice the quiet miracle in the next line, the one everybody skips: *eight days later, the disciples were together again, and this time Thomas was with them.*

He's still there. A week of not believing what everyone around him believes — the odd man out at every meal, the rain on their joy — and he didn't leave, and *they didn't make him*. Nobody handed Thomas an ultimatum. The community held a chair for a man who couldn't yet say the creed the rest of them were living on. Write that down, because it's this table's whole policy in one verse: doubt gets a seat. The doubter stayed in the room — which is the only reason he was present for what happened next.

Doors locked again. And suddenly Jesus is standing among them: "Peace be with you." And then he turns — and goes straight to Thomas. And here's the thing that should undo us: Jesus repeats Thomas's own words back to him. The exact

specification, the demand Thomas had made to the others in a locked room when Jesus wasn't — visibly — there: "Put your finger here, and look at my hands. Put your hand into the wound in my side." He'd heard the whole thing. He heard the doubt when it was spoken — and his response was not to strike Thomas off the list. It was to *come back*, for him, with the evidence in hand, saying in effect: you needed this? Here. "Don't be faithless any longer. Believe!"

No mockery. No "how dare you." No shaming lap in front of the others. The demanded proof, personally delivered, with an invitation attached.

And Thomas — and read carefully: John never says he actually touched; the offer itself seems to have been enough — Thomas answers with five words that go further than anyone in all four gospels had yet gone:

"My Lord — and my God!"

The bluntest doubter in the room produces the highest confession in the book. That's not an irony; it's a pattern. Faith that has been through the fire of honest doubt comes out weight-bearing. Thomas wouldn't say it until he could mean it — which is exactly why, when he said it, it meant everything.

And then Jesus says the sentence that leans out of the story and looks directly at your table: "You believe because you have seen me. Blessed are those who believe without seeing me."

That's us. Every person at every table since. He was already blessing the rooms he knew were coming — rooms where nobody gets the hands and the side, where the believing runs on the told story and the burning heart. And he blessed them in the same breath as answering a doubter's demand — which means both things are true forever: the doubt is welcome at this table, and the blessing is already spoken over everyone at it who believes anyway.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — that he heard the doubt, and what he did about it?
- 03 Where are you in this story — holding a specification of your own ("I can't believe unless...")? And has this table been the kind of room that keeps a chair for the Thomas week?

04 So what are we going to do about it?

AN ACT

Two-sided act. Say your doubt out loud this week — the real one, in its blunt Thomas wording — to God, or to this table; specification welcome. And be the room that kept him: if someone you know has drifted from faith or community because their questions made them feel like the odd one out, tell them plainly that there's a chair with their name on it here, doubts and all. No conditions. That's the policy, straight from the locked room.



## "Do You Love Me?"

Read it first: John 21:15–19

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### THE FIVE CS

#### CONTEXT

Breakfast on the beach is finished (story 30): the miraculous catch, the charcoal fire, the risen Jesus feeding the friend who denied him. Now, with the meal done, Jesus turns to Peter — beside the same kind of fire Peter's three denials happened beside.

#### CHARACTERS

Jesus. Simon Peter, restored but not yet re-commissioned. The other disciples nearby. And, in the background of every line: sheep.

#### CONFLICT

Three questions for three denials: *Simon son of John, do you love me?* Each yes is answered not with absolution language but with a job: *feed my lambs... take care of my sheep... feed my sheep*. By the third asking, Peter is hurt — and answers from the bottom: *Lord, you know everything. You know I love you.*

#### CLIMAX

The third exchange — the wound of the denial fully reopened and fully healed in the same motion, and the commission complete: the failed leader is handed the flock. Then Jesus tells him, gently, where this loving will lead — a death that would glorify God — and closes with the same two words that started everything years ago on this same shore: *Follow me*.

#### CHANGE

Restoration turns outward. Peter isn't just forgiven — he's *entrusted*, given people to feed, sent. The canon ends where the movement begins: love, asked and answered three times, immediately converted into care for others. Loving Jesus and feeding his people are, from this beach forward, the same assignment. Fifty stories in, that's the whole point of having heard them: now go feed somebody.

#### A SAMPLE TELLING

If your table remembers the beach — the empty night, the shout from shore, Peter swimming, the charcoal fire, breakfast made by the risen Lord for the friend who failed him — then you remember where we left it: fed, forgiven, warm. This is what happened when the plates were empty.

Jesus turns to Peter — beside that fire; remember, John names it a *charcoal* fire on purpose, the only other one in his gospel being the fire in the courtyard where Peter denied him three times — and asks:

"Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?"

Notice the name. Not "Peter" — the Rock, the nickname Jesus gave him. *Simon* son of *John* — his old name, his before-name, as if the question goes all the way down under the failure to the original man. And "more than these" — than the other disciples? Peter had once boasted exactly that: *even if all the others desert you, I never will*. The boast is being gently laid on the table next to what happened to it.

"Yes, Lord," Peter says — no boast this time, no comparisons — "you know I love you."

And Jesus says: "Then feed my lambs."

Mark what just happened, because it's the strangest and most wonderful move in the whole restoration: Peter says I love you, and Jesus answers with a job. Not "I forgive you" — that was the breakfast; that was already done. The proof that Peter is truly restored isn't a certificate. It's a flock. Jesus trusts him with the thing he loves most: *my lambs*. You don't hand your sheep to a man you're still holding at arm's length.

A second time: "Simon son of John, do you love me?" — "Yes, Lord, you know I love you." — "Then take care of my sheep."

And a third time: "Simon son of John, do you love me?"

And Peter was *hurt*, John tells us, that Jesus asked a third time. Of course he was — he can count. Three denials by a charcoal fire; three questions by a charcoal fire. Jesus is not rubbing it in. He's walking Peter back through the wound at its exact depth — one yes for every no — because a failure buried is a failure that runs your life from underneath, and a failure walked through, out loud, with the one you failed, loses its power for good. And Peter answers from the very bottom, with nothing left but honesty: "Lord, you know everything. You know I love you."

"Then feed my sheep."

Three denials, three questions, three yeses, three commissions. The restoration is complete — and look at its shape, because it's the shape of everything this canon has been teaching for fifty weeks: *love for Jesus turns immediately into care for people*. Peter isn't restored into a warm feeling. He's restored into a job with wool on it. From this beach forward, "do you love me?" and "will you feed them?" are one question. There is no loving Jesus that doesn't put food in front of his sheep — the church has been checked against that beach ever since, and so has every table.

Then Jesus tells Peter, tenderly and honestly, where the loving will lead — that the man who once ran from a servant girl's question will one day stretch out his hands and be led where he doesn't want to go, and that even his death will glorify God. The coward will die brave. Grace doesn't just cancel the past; it rewrites the ending.

And then the last two words. The same two words Jesus said to a fisherman on this same shore, years and a lifetime ago, standing in the fish:

"Follow me."

The whole story, first word to last, was always that sentence. And notice where the canon has landed you, fifty stories from where you started: the invitation at the beginning and the invitation at the end are the same invitation — only now you know who's asking, what it costs, what he's like at weddings and gravesides and courtrooms and breakfast fires, and what he does with people who fail him. He feeds them. And then he says: now you feed somebody.

That's the last story. So — the question the canon leaves on your table, in his words: *do you love me?* Then you know what to do.

#### THE FOUR QUESTIONS, TUNED

- 01 What stood out to you?
- 02 What does this show us about Jesus — how he restores, and what he does with restored people?
- 03 Where are you in this story — is there a failure he's inviting you to walk back through instead of around? And who are the sheep within your actual reach?
- 04 So what are we going to do about it?

**AN ACT**

The canon's final act, and it's the commissioning one: as a table, answer the beach question out loud — *who are our sheep*? Name the actual people and needs within this table's reach, choose one, and feed them this month — food, care, presence, whatever feeding means for them. And then ask the year-end question every table was built to ask: who around this table is ready to be sent to start the next one? Fifty stories are now in this room's bones. They were never meant to stay here.

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